Leadership Tool: The Eisenhower Matrix of Prioritization

To be an effective leader, two skills you will need for success are time management and decision making. One tool most successful leaders utilize in their toolbox is the Eisenhower Matrix. Getting its name from former U.S. President Dwight D. Eisenhower, who developed and utilized the tool, the tool was later popularized by thought leader Stephen Covey, in the book "The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People." The framework of the tool can help you prioritize, or make decisions, based on each task's urgency and importance. Set up as a 2x2 grid, it provides guidance for you to place each task into four different quadrants: (a) urgent and important; (b) not urgent and important; (c) urgent but not important; and (d) not urgent and not important (See Picture).

The following leadership resource article explores the Eisenhower Matrix, the different quadrants and provides practical examples of tasks that fit into each category. As a leader you can utilize this tool to determine your task priorities, allocate your time, resources, and energy appropriately, and have greater success with your time management.

Quadrant 1: Urgent and Important

The first quadrant to explore in the Eisenhower Matrix represents those tasks that demand immediate attention and the most likely to have consequences if the leader does not prioritize the tasks for completion. From a leadership perspective, these tasks can include those with looming deadlines, critical emergencies, or daily objectives. This includes those tasks that must get done so that other higher priority tasks, which depend on the task completion, can be accomplished. The reason a leader should prioritize the work in this quadrant is to mitigate any risk and to prevent any potential issues or problems. It is critical that these tasks are prioritized high, that the necessary time and resources are allocated to addressing these tasks, and that they are addressed early in the workday/week to address them in an efficient and effective manner. Tasks in the Urgent and Important quadrant, especially from the perspective of leadership include:

- **Employee Crises and Conflict Resolution**: Tasks that focus on urgent employee issues including employee conflict, crisis, or critical questions. These tasks are both urgent and important because they allow the leader to maintain a positive work culture, team cohesiveness, and can contribute to overall employee satisfaction/well-being.
- **Customer Crises and Complaints**: With a focus on excellent customer service, leaders will prioritize in the Urgent and Important quadrant customers crises or complaints that might detract from satisfaction or loyalty.
- **Quality Control and Risk Mitigation**: Any urgent product or process quality issues, including when potential risks are identified and/or the implementation of corrective actions to ensure product/service excellence and risk mitigation.
- **High-Priority Meetings**: The attendance by the leader in any meetings that address current or ongoing strategic planning, urgent decision making, or engagement with key stakeholders. This communication and possible influence of key stakeholders is always urgent and important for leaders to provide meaningful updates, address concerns, and continue to build strong collaborative relationships.
- **Deadline-Driven Projects**: Tasks with imminent deadlines that have a substantial impact on the achievement of team or organizational goals.

The urgent and important category of the Eisenhower matrix is often referred to as the "firefighting" elements of the leadership process, primarily due to the tasks in the category requiring leaders to quickly assess priorities, make decisions under stress, and move into action with proposed solutions. The more leaders can stay ahead of the potential urgencies presented in their work, the more likely they are to minimize burnout, risk, and the reoccurrence of the issue. In order to stay ahead of these urgent and important tasks, leaders can utilize tools like time blocking and effective communication to increase success. By setting aside specific time blocks in the leader's calendar, dedicated to these high priority tasks, the leader will have significantly less interrupted time and be able to focus their energy on the most important elements of their role. Taking time at the beginning and end of every day to reflect on urgent and important tasks and scheduling them appropriately is essential in high performing leadership. Additionally, effective communication practices allow the leader to collaborate with others on these tasks and ensure that all deadlines are achieved.

Activity:

Take a few moments to map out the urgent/important tasks of your leadership role and place them in the urgent/important quadrant.

Quadrant 2: Not Urgent but Important

One of the major mistakes often made by well-intentioned leaders happens in the not urgent but important quadrant of the Eisenhower Matrix. Since these particular tasks do not carry a sense of stress and anxiety to move to completion, often these are the first tasks that are

deprioritized to other more urgent tasks, even if they are not as important. However, the Not Urgent but Important quadrant is where the most effective leaders shine. In this category, the tasks do not seem as pressing but hold a great amount of significance for personal and professional growth. By dedicating both time and energy into the tasks in this quadrant leaders have the best chance for long term success. The Not Urgent but Important quadrant is characterized by the potential long term impact these tasks can have on goal attainment, leadership development and department/organizational success. Examples include:

- **Strategic Planning**: Effective leaders develop long term strategies that will continue to address challenges they are facing and find new opportunities for growth. A part of the strategic planning process is setting clear objectives, goal setting, and moving the leader's team towards the future.
- **Leadership Development and Personal Growth**: Continuous learning is critical for personal growth, including self-improvement or skill development, and investing in leadership training. The focus on growth not only makes one a better leader but reinforces the need for the team to continual develop their skills and abilities.
- **Relationship Building**: A critical emphasis should be placed on relationship building and networking to grow as an effective leader. The time spent on cultivating relationships with colleagues, stakeholders, other industry peers will pay huge dividends when trying to acquire resources or move strategic plans forward.
- **Innovation and Creativity**: Consistent emphasis on encouraging a culture of innovation, brainstorming, and critical thinking can both help drive growth and address issues before they become significant problems. It is necessary to dedicate time and energy on a regular basis to build a culture that drives growth and is ready to adapt to changing environments.
- **Delegation and Empowerment**: While the process of delegation and empowerment will save the leader time in the long run, the initial tasks require energy and time up front. Leaders need to take the time to support employees and communicate ownership of the task prior to turning it over to the employee. Some initial coaching is necessary to ensure the employee has the best chance for success.

Part of the success of effective leaders comes from being able to evaluate current tasks and behaviors and being able to categories them into the different quadrants of the matrix. It is critically important that leaders learn to identify the tasks that align with the Not Urgent and Important quadrant due to their importance on long term success. Often leaders will push these tasks off, not realizing the impact this is having on their growth and the organization's success. Once you have time blocked the Urgent and Important tasks for the week, it is in the best interest of your leadership to time block the tasks that fall into the Not Urgent but Important quadrant.

Activity:

Take a few moments to map out the not urgent/important tasks of your leadership role and place them in the not urgent/important quadrant.

Quadrant 3: Urgent but not Important

The Urgent but Not Important quadrant of the Eisenhower matrix consists of those tasks that often steal time away from the two "Important" quadrants of the matrix. These tasks are characterized by their perception of needing immediate attention but lack the significant long-term impact leaders should prioritize for department or organizational success. Once again, these tasks can be deceptive, as it can appear that there is a great sense of urgency to get them completed, often distracting the leader from more pressing matters. Truly effective leaders can quickly identify these tasks (not getting caught up in the stress associated with their perceived urgency) and diagnose the little strategic value associated with their prioritization. It is critical that leaders do not react to these trivial issues and distractions, which can compromise their focus on higher-impact responsibilities. These tasks can include:

- **Responding to non-urgent emails and messages**: While leaders need to make sure communication is a critical part of their daily routine, both the time dedicated to email and dedicating time to every email can steal time away from other important tasks.
- **Attending low-priority meetings or conference calls**: Leaders can get into the habit of attending meetings that lack clear agendas or meaningful outcomes, diverting their attention away from essential tasks. Additionally, when employees ask for "5 minutes" but take up much more time, this can feel urgent but is ultimately not as important for the time invested. Avenues to build strong relationships and communication should be balanced with boundaries around time for strategic goals.
- **Completing trivial administrative work**: While some administrative work helps to organize and collaborate on an organizational level, the amount of administrative work should be balanced against opportunities to use this time for more strategic and critical thinking. The opportunity cost for leaders, in an organization, to spend significant time on administrative tasks comes at a cost of relationship building, problem solving and strategic goals.

The first step for leaders to address tasks in the urgent but not important category is to identify which tasks give the impression of urgency but take the leader away from other desired goals (including strategic goals, limiting burnout/stress, opportunities for productivity, and effective leadership of their team). Once identified, the urgent but not important tasks can be prioritized and delegated to free up time for the leader. While leaders often like to have control over all aspects of their job, to free up time for more important opportunities, delegation is critical. Additionally, leaders might find help by automating repetitive tasks like email filtering, appointment scheduling or even data entry. Finally, it is critical for leaders to consistently review tasks to assess whether they can be eliminated to free up bandwidth for both themselves and others on their team.

Activity:

Take a few moments to map out the urgent/not important tasks of your leadership role and place them in the urgent/not important quadrant.

Learning to politely decline from taking on non-essential tasks is a great step to dedicate more time to your people and strategic goals.

Quadrant 4: Not Important and Not Urgent

The Not Urgent and Not Important quadrant in the Eisenhower Matrix encompasses tasks that lack immediate urgency and contribute minimally (if at all) to long-term objectives. While it seems like it would be easy not to worry about this quadrant, due to the lack of positive returns for a leader, all too often leaders engage in activities that align with this quadrant. It is critical for those looking to be effective leaders to reflect on how these timewasters and distractions are being prioritized (consciously or unconsciously) daily. Additional, proactive measures should be taken to limit the time leaders are investing in tasks that fall into the Not Urgent and Not Important quadrant. By doing so, leaders can recover a significant amount of time during their day and create more overall balance in their lives. Examples of tasks in this quadrant include:

- **Mindless internet browsing and social media use**: Internet browsing, and social media use can lead to addiction and overuse, which can negatively impact a leaders' energy, time, and overall effectiveness. This use does not reference the internet browsing and/or social media needed to be successful in one's job or used for personal/professional development.
- **Engaging in gossip or non-work-related conversations**: Leaders need to balance building relationships and a healthy work culture with the time/energy cost of gossip and non-work-related conversations. These negative communication patterns not only take away time from other important leadership tasks, but there is also an increase in potential workplace conflicts or miscommunication. Additionally, leaders set the example for what they expect of those on their team. Positive relationships and task building communication is important for all members.
- **Unproductive meetings with no clear purpose or outcomes**: Often we establish repeat weekly and monthly meetings that just exist on the calendar but often do not have any level of importance. The meetings occur because at one point they were important and urgent. Consistently be questioning if the meetings you set up a year ago are still relevant today.
- **Engaging in busy work that does not contribute to the strategic goals**: These activities can include excessive data entry, pointless reporting, excessive documentation, over-organizing, procrastination, or duplicating efforts across the company. Additionally, as a leader this can include micromanaging your team or striving for an unrealistic perfectionism.

Once again, the first step to addressing tasks in this category, to free up time for more effective leadership, is to self-reflect on the work you are doing as a leader. A beneficial exercise is to keep notes of how you are spending your time over the next week. In 15-minute increments keep track of the time you spend on all your activities. Pay special attention to the amount of time you put into social media scrolling, engaging in non-work related (or goal achieving) communication. The list of activities you collect over the week will point to the time you spend engaging in non-urgent and non-important tasks. While some engagement in these activities is to be expected, the trick is to limit the time you put into these activities each week and invest that time into those activities that are non-urgent but so important.

Activity:

Take a few moments to map out the not urgent/not important tasks of your leadership role and place them in the not urgent/not important quadrant.

Eisenhower Matrix

DATE: _____/_____/_____

IMPORTANT, NOT URGENT Decide when to do (Task & Date)	**IMPORTANT & URGENT** Do immediately/Today (Task)
NOT IMPORTANT & NOT URGENT Do later, Automate or Delete (Task)	**NOT IMPORTANT & URGENT** Delegate (Task & Who)

NOTES: